empires as oppressive, the modern Chinese political dispensation seeks to project itself as their successor state, entitled to the territorial acquisitions of those empires, including vast non-Han areas such as Xinjiang and Tibet.

It is apparent that an imagined history is being put forward by China to seek legitimacy for its claim to Asian hegemony. What is remarkable is how much of this contrived history is being considered as self-evident in Western and even Indian discourse. There is little in history to support the proposition that China was indeed the centre of the Asian universe, commanding deference among less civilized states around its periphery. It is on the basis of its contemporary economic and military capabilities, its accumulation of knowledge capital, its mastery of science and technology, and, above all, its contribution to the global commons that it must claim its rightful place in the emerging world order. Its contemporary rise is indeed remarkable but does not entitle it to claim a fictitious centrality bestowed upon it by history.

In reality, we are not in a China-centric Asia, let alone a China-centric world. China may continue to expand its economic and military capabilities and may even become the most powerful country in the world. But the world which is emerging will be home to a cluster of major powers, both old and new, including in Asia. The Chinese economy is slowing down, as has been the case with every major economy in the past. It has an ageing population, an ecologically ravaged landscape, and mounting debt which is now over 300 per cent of GDP. A simple linear projection of Chinese current growth into the future may not be realistic. China also remains a brittle and opaque polity, and the rising insecurity within its political leadership sits uneasily with its overweening arrogance of power and hubris. Its historical insularity is at odds with the cosmopolitanism which a densely interconnected contemporary world demands of any aspiring global power.

When Count Bismarck had successfully created a powerful German state at the heart of Europe, he was conscious of the anxieties among European states which would seek to constrain and countervail Germany's expanding influence. He called this the '*cauchemar*' of coalitions, or the nightmare of